

WORKBOOK

1.6

Myth & Symbols of **Power** Greece

How the Greeks used myth in stone to celebrate civilisation over barbarism – the Centauromachy on the Parthenon and the Amazonomachy on the Temple of Apollo at Bassae.

NAME

SET / FORM

TOPIC 1.6 · GREECE

What's in this **booklet**?

A guided study of two prescribed visual sources: the Centauromachy on the Parthenon, and the Amazonomachy on the Temple of Apollo at Bassae — what each myth shows, how it's sculpted, and what it really means.

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- A** **Key vocabulary** — metopes, friezes, and the terms you must know.
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- B** **Context** — myth as a symbol of power, and the Persian Wars.
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- C** **The Parthenon** — what it is, who built it and why.
-
- D** **The Centauromachy myth** — Lapiths, Centaurs and Theseus.
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- E** **The Centauromachy on the Parthenon** — the south metopes.
-
- F** **Annotation: four Parthenon metopes** — scenes to study and annotate.
-
- G** **The Temple of Apollo at Bassae** — where, when, and why.
-
- H** **The Amazonomachy myth** — Heracles, Hippolyte and the Amazons.
-
- I** **The Amazonomachy at Bassae** — the continuous inner frieze.
-
- J** **Annotation: three scenes from the Bassae frieze** — scenes to study.
-
- K** **Connecting the dots** — how both buildings use myth as power.
-
- L** **Topic check & exam practice** — recall plus exam-style questions.
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AT A GLANCE

TOPIC

1.6 Greece

SPEC AREA

Myth & Religion

PRESCRIBED SOURCES

The Parthenon metopes · The Bassae frieze

SECTIONS

12 sections

WHAT OCR ASKS

1. How and why myth is presented in art to demonstrate power.
2. The significance of where the myth was sited or displayed.

SECTION A

Key vocabulary

Eight terms central to the topic — some about architecture, some about the myths themselves. Learn the word, what it means, and where you'll see it in the booklet.

metope	A square panel of carved relief sculpture, set above the columns of a Greek temple. The Parthenon has 92 of them.	frieze	A continuous band of sculpted decoration along a wall. The Bassae frieze runs around the inside of the naos.
naos	The inner chamber of a Greek temple, where the cult statue stood.	Centauromachy	The mythical battle between the Lapiths and the Centaurs. Sculpted on the south metopes of the Parthenon.
Amazonomachy	The mythical battles between the Greeks and the Amazons. The Bassae frieze shows the 'Heraclean' Amazonomachy.	Lapiths	A mythical race of men from Thessaly. They represented civilisation — orderly, hospitable, religious.
Centaurs	Mythical creatures, half-man and half-horse. They represented savagery and wild instinct.	Amazons	A mythical race of female warriors from Asia Minor. They always sided against the Greeks.

Exercise A.1 — Match the term

Match each term to its definition. Write the correct letter in the box.

- ☐ **metope**
- ☐ **frieze**
- ☐ **Centauromachy**
- ☐ **naos**

- A. The mythical battle between Lapiths and Centaurs.
- B. A continuous band of sculpted decoration.
- C. A square panel of relief sculpture above the columns.
- D. The inner chamber of a Greek temple.

Exercise A.2 — Quick recall

1. What is the difference between a *metope* and a *frieze*? [2]

2. What did the *Centaurs* represent symbolically, and what did the *Lapiths* represent? [2]

SECTION B

Myth as a symbol of power

Greek and Roman myths were never just stories. They could be powerful political symbols too – tools for showing who you were, who your enemies were, and what your city stood for.

Civilisation vs barbarism

The Greek world thought of itself as *civilised*: orderly, religious, capable of art and proper conduct. Everyone outside the Greek world was a *barbaros* – a barbarian, an outsider. Myths that pitted the Greeks against unruly enemies could be read as the same battle: civilisation against chaos. Two myths in particular came to stand for this contrast:

- **The Centauromachy** – Lapiths (civilised men) versus Centaurs (savage half-beasts) at a wedding ruined by drunken violence.
- **The Amazonomachy** – Greeks versus Amazons (foreign women warriors from Asia Minor) in repeated battles.

The Persian Wars

The reason these myths gained such political force was real history. Between 490 and 479 BC, the Greeks fought off two attempted invasions by the Persian Empire. In 480 BC the Persians **sacked Athens**, burning the Acropolis and destroying an earlier temple to Athena. The Greeks defeated them decisively at the Battle of Plataea in 479 BC.

From that moment on, the Persians became *the* image of barbarism in the Greek imagination. Sculptors who depicted Centaurs or Amazons being defeated were really showing Persians being defeated – without ever needing to say so.

Where myth was displayed

The site of the myth mattered as much as the myth itself. A scene high up on the most important temple in Athens carried a different message than one tucked inside a remote rural shrine. As you read on, ask: **why was this myth chosen for this building?**

KEY DATES

- 490 BC – Battle of Marathon (first Persian invasion repulsed)
- 480 BC – Persians sack Athens
- 479 BC – Battle of Plataea (Persians defeated)
- 449 BC – Pericles rebuilds the Parthenon
- 450 BC – Iktinos begins work at Bassae

TWO QUESTIONS TO KEEP ASKING

1. How and why is myth being used here?
2. What does the site or location of the myth add to its meaning?

SECTION C

The Parthenon

The most famous temple in the ancient world. Built under Pericles, dedicated to Athena, and decorated with mythical battles on every side.

What and where

The Parthenon stands on the **Acropolis** in Athens. Its name comes from *parthenos*, meaning 'virgin' — one of the titles of the goddess Athena, to whom the temple is dedicated. It measures roughly 70 metres long and 31 metres wide.

Who built it and why

The temple was the centrepiece of a building programme led by **Pericles**, the statesman who dominated Athens during its golden age. He rebuilt it in **449 BC** after the Persians had destroyed the earlier temple in 480 BC. Athens paid for the work with money from the **Delian League** — a treasury intended for collective defence, controversially diverted by Pericles to build up the city.

The Parthenon was both a religious building and a political statement. It housed a 13-metre statue of Athena designed by the sculptor **Phidias**. It also held the city's treasury. And it told the story of Athens itself in stone.

Sculpture everywhere

The Parthenon was decorated more heavily than any temple before it. Four sets of sculpture covered the building:

- **The pediments** — the triangular spaces at each end, showing the birth of Athena and her contest with Poseidon
- **The metopes** — 92 square panels around the outside, each showing a separate mythical battle
- **The Ionic frieze** — a continuous band inside the colonnade, showing the Panathenaic procession
- **The cult statue** — Athena Parthenos by Phidias, inside the naos

Of the 92 metopes, **32** showed scenes from the Centauromachy, on the south side of the temple.

PARTHENON FACTS

- Built 447–432 BC (started 449 BC)
- On the Acropolis in Athens
- Dedicated to Athena
- Architect: Iktinos (also of Bassae)
- Sculptor-in-chief: Phidias
- 92 metopes total — 32 of them Centauromachy
- Paid for with Delian League funds

WHY IT MATTERS

After the Persian sack of 480 BC, rebuilding the Parthenon was as much an act of defiance as devotion. It announced that Athens had survived — and that no enemy could keep it down.

SECTION D

The Centauromachy myth

The Centauromachy is a story about a wedding that turned into a battle. Knowing the myth makes every metope on the Parthenon make sense.

The Lapiths and the Centaurs

The Lapiths were a mythical race of men based in **Thessaly**, in northern Greece. They were ruled by King **Ixion**, who once made the mistake of trying to seduce Hera. Zeus tricked him by creating a cloud in Hera's shape; Ixion coupled with the cloud, and the children born from this strange union were the **Centaurs** — half-man, half-horse. So the Centaurs were technically the Lapiths' relatives.

But the two races could not have been more different. The Lapiths were civilised: orderly, hospitable, capable of crafts, religion and proper behaviour. The Centaurs were savage: they lived in caves, hunted with rocks, and had no understanding of how to behave at a ceremony.

The wedding of Pirithous

The story's key moment came at the wedding of **Pirithous**, son of Ixion and king of the Lapiths, to **Hippodamia**. The Lapiths invited the Centaurs as wedding guests — an attempt to mend the family feud. They also invited their friend **Theseus** of Athens.

The Centaurs, who had no experience of wine, drank it unmixed with water. They became uncontrollably drunk and attacked the Lapith women. The Lapiths fought back. As Plutarch puts it:

'When these were flown with insolence and wine, and laid hands upon the women, the Lapiths took vengeance upon them ... Theseus fighting with them at the banquet and in the war.'

PLUTARCH, THESEUS 30.3

Theseus and the Lapiths defeated the Centaurs and drove them from Thessaly.

What the myth came to mean

The Centauromachy came to stand for one big idea: **civilisation versus barbarism**. After 479 BC, that contrast had a very specific real-world reference: Greeks (civilised) defeating Persians (barbarian). Showing Centaurs being defeated was a way of showing Persians being defeated — on a temple, in stone, forever.

CAST OF THE MYTH

- **Pirithous** — Lapith king, groom
- **Hippodamia** — his bride
- **Theseus** — Athenian hero, ally
- **Ixion** — old Lapith king, the Centaurs' father

THESEUS — WHY THIS MATTERS FOR ATHENS

Theseus was the legendary king of Athens. His role in defeating the Centaurs gave Athenians a special claim on the myth — their hero was on the right side. When this scene appears on an Athenian temple, the message is unmistakable: Athens defeats the barbarian.

SECTION E

The Centauromachy on the Parthenon

The Centauromachy appears on the **south metopes** of the Parthenon — 32 panels showing the battle in different scenes. Each one had to work as a single, recognisable moment of the myth.

Where the metopes sat

The metopes ran around the outside of the building, set **about ten metres above the ground**, above the columns. They were carved in deep relief and originally painted in bright colours. From below, viewers would see them silhouetted against the sky — designed to be read at a glance from ground level.

A team of sculptors

92 metopes was too much for one sculptor. The job went to a **team**, with different artists working on different panels. This is why the quality and finish varies from one metope to the next — some are masterpieces; others are clearly workshop pieces. Phidias oversaw the whole project but did not carve every panel himself.

What each metope had to do

The sculptor had three jobs on every panel:

1. **Create a recognisable scene** — the viewer must know instantly which moment of the myth this is.
2. **Create realism** — muscles, movement, expression. The figures should look real.
3. **Fill the space** — the square panel should be visually balanced, with no big blank areas.

Successful metopes capture a Centaur rearing triumphantly over a Lapith, or a Lapith pulling a Centaur down by the hair, in a single dramatic moment. The use of **high relief** on key figures and **low relief** on details (a raised arm in the background) makes the carvings visible from beneath.

The political message

Of the 92 metopes around the Parthenon, every side showed a battle: north (Trojan War), east (Gods vs Giants), west (Greeks vs Amazons), and south (Centauromachy). Together they made a single argument: **order defeats chaos, Greeks defeat barbarians**, and the gods (and Athens) are on the right side of every battle.

HOW TO SPOT A CENTAUR

- Lower body of a **horse** (four legs, tail)
- Upper body of a **man** from the waist up
- Usually **bearded** and wild-looking
- Often **rearing** — on hind legs, attacking
- Sometimes holding a rock or club as a weapon

HOW TO SPOT A LAPITH

- Fully **human** figure — two legs, normal body
- Usually **clean-shaven** and youthful
- Wearing or carrying a **cloak**
- Often grappling the Centaur by the **hair** or **neck**
- If fallen, the Lapith is the one being trampled

QUICK FACTS

32 of 92 metopes · south side · about 10m up · team of sculptors · deep relief · originally painted

SECTION F

Annotation: four Parthenon metopes

Four scenes from the south metopes of the Parthenon. Study each one, then annotate around the image: what is happening, who is winning, how the sculptor has filled the space, and how successful you think the scene is.

SCENE 1



SCENE 2

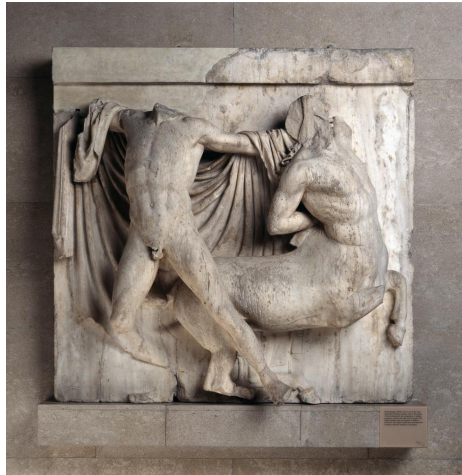


SECTION F · CONTINUED

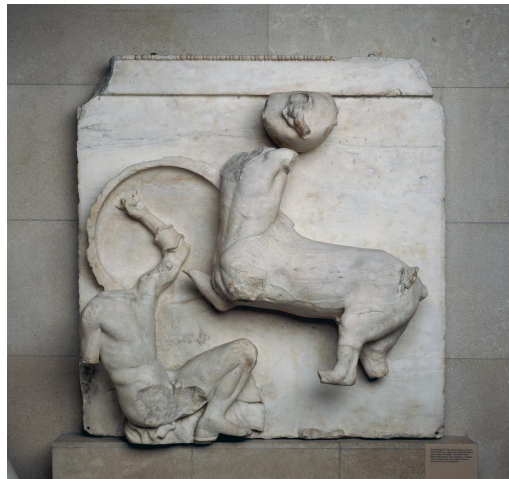
Annotation: Parthenon metopes (continued)

Two more scenes from the south metopes. Study and annotate as before.

SCENE 3



SCENE 4



SECTION G

The Temple of Apollo at Bassae

A small temple in a remote mountainous spot — nothing like the Parthenon at first glance. But it shares an architect, a designer's instinct, and one of the same political messages.

Where it is

Bassae was a small town about **36 miles south-east of Olympia**, in the western part of the Peloponnese. It sits high in the mountains, geographically isolated — not the kind of place you would expect to find one of the most admired temples in the Greek world. The Greek writer Pausanias rated it second only to the Temple of Athena Alea at Tegea for the beauty of its stone and the elegance of its design.

Why it was built

The temple was dedicated to **Apollo Epikourios**, 'Apollo the Helper'. According to Pausanias, the people of Bassae built it as a thanksgiving offering after Apollo had spared them from a **plague**. The dedication name is unusual — most temples to Apollo emphasise other aspects of the god (Apollo Pythios, Apollo Delphinios) — and the 'Helper' title speaks to a community that felt it had been rescued.

Who designed it

Work began around **450 BC**. The architect was **Iktinos** — the same man who would later design the Parthenon in Athens. This is one reason the temple is so admired: it has a master architect's instinct for proportion, despite its rural location.

An unusual design

Several features of the Bassae temple are **unusual** for Greek temple architecture:

- It faces **north** rather than east, the standard direction.
- It has a small **side door** facing east, possibly to let in morning light to illuminate the cult statue.
- Most strikingly, it has a **continuous Ionic frieze inside the naos** — an unusual choice. Most Greek temples kept friezes on the outside.

That inside frieze is what concerns us. It runs around all four walls of the inner chamber. Viewers standing inside the naos could take in the whole narrative without moving — a real advantage for telling a continuous story.

BASSAE FACTS

- Begun 450 BC
- Architect: **Iktinos** (also of the Parthenon)
- Dedicated to **Apollo Epikourios** ('the Helper')
- Built after a plague spared the town
- High in the western Peloponnese
- Famous for its inner frieze

WHY THIS TEMPLE IS UNIQUE

Most Greek temples display their decoration on the outside, where everyone can see it. Bassae puts its most important sculpture *inside the naos*. Only those who entered the temple could view it — making the frieze a private message to worshippers rather than a public statement.

SECTION H

The Amazonomachy myth

The Amazonomachy is the story of repeated battles between Greek heroes and a race of female warriors from the east. Like the Centauromachy, it became shorthand for Greeks defeating barbarians.

Who were the Amazons?

The Amazons were a mythical race of **female warriors** who lived in **Asia Minor** (the western two-thirds of modern Turkey). According to myth, they kept entirely apart from men except when they needed to produce children — and even then, only girls were raised in the tribe. If a son was born, he was killed or abandoned.

The Amazons were everything a normal Greek city was *not*. They were women fighting like men. They were foreign, coming from the east. And in every story Greek writers told about them, they always ended up **fighting against the Greeks**.

The first battle: Heracles and Hippolyte

The first great battle was over **Hippolyte**, queen of the Amazons. As his **ninth labour**, Heracles was sent to fetch Hippolyte's belt. The queen was willing to give it up peacefully, but the goddess **Hera** took the form of an Amazon and spread a rumour that Heracles had come to abduct Hippolyte. The Amazons attacked. Heracles defeated them and took the belt — the Heracleian Amazonomachy.

The second battle: the Attic War

After this, Heracles brought back an Amazon bride for his friend **Theseus** of Athens. Furious that two of their queens had been taken, the Amazons invaded Greece and attacked Athens itself. This was the **Attic War**. **Theseus and Heracles led an Athenian army** against them and won. The Amazonomachy was once again a defeat of foreign invaders — this time on Greek soil.

What it came to mean

Like the Centauromachy, the Amazonomachy came to stand for **Greeks triumphing over foreign peoples**. After the Persian Wars, that meant the Persians. The Amazons came from Asia Minor — the same region the Persian Empire dominated — so the comparison was easy. Showing Greek heroes defeating Amazons was another way of saying that the Greeks had defeated the East.

TWO GREAT BATTLES

- **The Heracleian Amazonomachy** — Heracles defeats Hippolyte for her belt (9th Labour). Shown at Bassae.
- **The Attic War** — Amazons invade Athens; Theseus and Heracles defeat them.

HOW TO SPOT AN AMAZON

- Always a **woman**
- Wearing armour, sometimes a **short tunic**
- Often on **horseback**
- Carrying a **spear**, axe or **bow**
- Sometimes wearing a **Phrygian cap** (eastern-style headgear)

SECTION I

The Amazonomachy at Bassae

The Bassae frieze runs around all four walls inside the naos. Half of it shows the Amazonomachy; the other half shows the Centauromachy. Two prescribed symbols, paired up.

Where the frieze sits

The frieze is a continuous Ionic frieze inside the naos, around all four walls. Worshippers entering the temple would look up and see it framing the space. Because the viewer could stand in one place and see the entire narrative, the frieze worked as a single, unfolding story — very different from the Parthenon's metopes, which are independent panels.

Which Amazonomachy?

The frieze shows the **Heracleian Amazonomachy** — the battle in which Heracles takes Hippolyte's belt. We can be confident of this because Heracles himself appears on one of the south blocks, identifiable by his trademark **lion-skin cloak**. The scene runs along the east and south-east end of the frieze.

Paired with the Centauromachy

At Bassae, the Amazonomachy is twinned with a Centauromachy on the rest of the frieze. The pairing repeats the Parthenon's logic: **two myths, one message**. Civilised Greeks defeating foreigners, women warriors and half-beasts alike.

Why this myth here?

For a small, isolated town to commission a temple of this quality was a way of **declaring its Greekness**. The community of Bassae wanted to belong to the larger Greek world — to stand alongside Athens and Olympia as a participant in Greek culture. Choosing the Amazonomachy and Centauromachy was a way of saying: *we share the same victories, the same symbols, the same identity*.

The sculptor's challenges

A continuous frieze faces different design problems than a single metope. The sculptor must:

- Make every scene **recognisable** on its own.
- Carry the story **across the joins** between blocks — you should be able to follow the action smoothly from one block to the next.
- Create **variety** across many figures so the eye does not get bored.

BASSAE FRIEZE FACTS

- Continuous Ionic frieze
- Inside the naos, around all four walls
- Half Amazonomachy, half Centauromachy
- The Heracleian Amazonomachy specifically
- Heracles identifiable by his lion-skin cloak
- Scene runs along east and south-east walls

METOPE VS FRIEZE

Parthenon metope: a single self-contained scene. Bassae frieze: a continuous narrative. Both tell the same kinds of stories — in very different ways.

SECTION J

Annotation: scenes from the Bassae frieze

Two scenes from the Amazonomachy frieze. The frieze runs in long rectangular blocks. Study each one, then annotate around the image: what is happening, who is winning, how the sculptor has filled the space, and how successful you think the scene is.

SCENE 1



SCENE 2



SECTION J · CONTINUED

Annotation: Bassae frieze (continued)

Two more scenes from the Amazonomachy frieze. Study and annotate as before.

SCENE 3



SCENE 4



SECTION K

Connecting the dots

The Parthenon and Bassae are very different buildings, but they use myth in strikingly similar ways. The OCR spec asks how and why myth was used to demonstrate power, and what the location of the myth adds to its meaning.

ASPECT	THE PARTHENON	TEMPLE OF APOLLO, BASSAE
Which myth Which mythical battle is shown?		
Where displayed Inside or outside? Public or private view?		
Form of sculpture Metope or frieze? Single scene or continuous?		
Audience Who saw it, and what did it tell them?		
Political message What is the myth being used to say?		
Significance of site What does the location add to its meaning?		

SECTION L

Topic check

Recall questions across the whole topic. Test what you know before moving on to exam-style practice.

Exercise L.1 – Topic check

1. What is a *metope*? [1]

2. How many metopes did the Parthenon have in total, and how many showed the Centauromachy? [2]

3. Name **two** features of the Centaurs that made them symbols of barbarism. [2]

4. Who was the architect of both the Parthenon and the Temple of Apollo at Bassae? [1]

5. Why was the Temple of Apollo at Bassae built? [1]

6. Whose belt did Heracles take in his ninth labour? [1]

7. Name **two** ways the Bassae temple is unusual in its design. [2]

8. Why did the Centauromachy take on a new meaning after the Persian Wars? [2]

SECTION L · CONTINUED

Exam-style practice

Exam-style questions on the prescribed visual sources. Mark allocation ranges from 1 to 4.

Exercise L.2 – Exam-style

1. Identify **one** sculptural feature of the Parthenon metopes that helped them be visible from below. [1]

2. Give **two** reasons why the Athenians may have chosen the Centauromachy for the Parthenon. [2]

3. Describe how the sculptor of a Parthenon metope works to create a successful scene. Refer to **three** features. [3]

4. Explain how the location of the Bassae frieze inside the temple affects its meaning. [4]
